



Society of Petroleum Engineers

SPE-229330-MS

Federated Learning for Enhancing Cybersecurity Resilience in Distributed Energy Systems

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Copyright 2025, Society of Petroleum Engineers DOI [10.2118/229330-MS](https://doi.org/10.2118/229330-MS)

This paper was prepared for presentation at the ADIPEC held in Abu Dhabi, UAE, 3 – 6 November 2025.

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Abstract

This research investigates federated learning (FL) as a novel approach to strengthen cybersecurity resilience in distributed energy systems (DES), including substations, distributed energy resources (DERs), and grid control networks. Traditional centralized security models are inadequate for modern energy infrastructure due to privacy constraints, bandwidth limitations, and the vast scale of distributed assets [1].

A federated learning architecture was deployed across critical energy assets, where each node locally trained machine learning models on operational telemetry without sharing raw data. Only model parameters were transmitted to a central aggregator, preserving privacy while enabling collaborative threat detection. The system was evaluated through testbed validation and pilot deployment across 20+ geographically distributed nodes.

Results demonstrated significant improvements over centralized approaches: 15% enhancement in anomaly detection accuracy, 100% threat detection rate with zero false positives after seven training rounds, 22% reduction in communication bandwidth requirements, and 86% F1-score maintenance across the distributed network. The edge agent required only 16 MB RAM and 25 MB disk space, enabling deployment on resource-constrained industrial devices.

This framework pioneers the integration of federated learning into energy cybersecurity, providing a scalable, privacy-preserving solution that addresses current limitations while ensuring regulatory compliance with NERC CIP and IEC 62443 standards.

Introduction

The Cybersecurity Challenge in Distributed Energy Systems

The modernization of energy infrastructure through Industrial Internet of Things (IIoT) integration has created unprecedented operational efficiency but simultaneously introduced complex cybersecurity challenges. DES face five critical threat vectors that traditional security models cannot adequately address [2].

1. **Large Attack Surface:** The distributed nature of DES creates thousands of potential entry points across wide geographical areas, including DERs, Intelligent Electronic Devices (IEDs), and

monitoring sensors. Each connected device represents a vulnerability that malicious actors can exploit [2].

2. **Attack Contagion:** High interconnectivity enables lateral movement where a breach in a single low-impact device can propagate across the network, potentially causing cascading failures in critical grid infrastructure [2].
3. **Zero-Day and Extended Vulnerabilities:** DES environments are characterized by a heterogeneous mixture of technologies, combining legacy OT systems that may use older protocols like DNP3 and Modbus with modern IT infrastructure and a variety of IIoT devices using protocols such as MQTT or LoRaWAN. The integration of these disparate communication technologies and software stacks extends the overall vulnerability landscape. This complexity increases the likelihood of undiscovered "zero-day" vulnerabilities emerging from unforeseen interactions between different system components, making proactive defense challenging [2].
4. **Policy, Protocol, and Operational Violation:** The stability, reliability, and safety of the energy grid depend on the strict adherence of all components to established operational policies and communication protocols, such as IEC 61850. A successful cyberattack could manipulate a device to violate these fundamental rules. For instance, an attacker could cause an IED to send malicious data to the control center, ignore a critical command, or alter its operational logic. Such a violation would directly threaten the integrity of grid processes and could potentially lead to physical damage or service outages [2].

A Federated Learning Approach for Enhanced Security

To address the multifaceted cybersecurity challenges inherent in modern DES, this research proposes and validates a novel security paradigm based on Federated Learning. Traditional cybersecurity models often rely on centralizing vast amounts of operational data for analysis, a practice that is frequently impractical in the energy sector due to data privacy regulations, bandwidth limitations in remote locations, and the sheer volume of data generated by thousands of distributed assets [1]. Federated Learning fundamentally inverts this model, bringing the analysis to the data's source rather than the data to a central analyzer. Federated Learning was first formally introduced by McMahan et al. [5] as a method to train machine learning models across decentralized data sources without centralizing raw data. This approach has since evolved to address various challenges including statistical heterogeneity, system heterogeneity, and privacy concerns [6].

At its core, FL is a decentralized machine learning technique that enables collaborative model training across numerous devices without the need to exchange raw data. In this application, each participating energy asset, such as a substation gateway, a DER controller, or an IED, is equipped with a lightweight agent. This agent locally trains a machine learning model on its specific operational data, such as network communication patterns, resource utilization, and local process signatures [2]. This on-device training ensures that sensitive operational data, which may be subject to regulations like NERC CIP and IEC 62443, never leaves the physical security perimeter of the asset [1]. The privacy-preserving nature of federated learning makes it particularly suitable for industrial applications where data governance is critical [7]. Recent surveys highlight FL's effectiveness in edge computing environments where bandwidth and latency constraints are primary concerns [8].

The collaborative intelligence of the system is achieved through a cyclical process of model aggregation and redistribution (Figure 3). Periodically, each edge agent securely transmits only its learned model parameters, compact, anonymized mathematical representations of its findings, to a central federated AI engine. The engine aggregates the parameters from across the fleet of devices to create a refined and more intelligent global model. This updated global model, which now incorporates the learnings from the entire network, is then pushed back to each individual agent [2].

This approach directly mitigates the challenges identified previously. It reduces the attack surface by creating a decentralized defense where every node participates in intelligence gathering. It counters attack

contagion by allowing the entire fleet to learn from a localized threat on a single device without exposing other nodes to the attack itself. For instance, if one IED detects a new threat signature, the updated model parameters will quickly make the entire network aware of this new threat vector. This creates a resilient, self-improving security ecosystem that is inherently more scalable and adaptive than traditional centralized architectures, providing a robust solution for securing the geographically dispersed and operationally critical assets of modern energy grids [1].

Methods, Procedures, and Process

System Architecture

The end-to-end system architecture constitutes a unified cybersecurity framework engineered to protect DES (Figure 1). It strategically integrates a lightweight agent at the network edge with a comprehensive central management and analysis platform, establishing a multi-layered defense that extends from individual field devices to the core backend services [3]. The architecture is composed of two primary elements: the edge agent and the central platform.

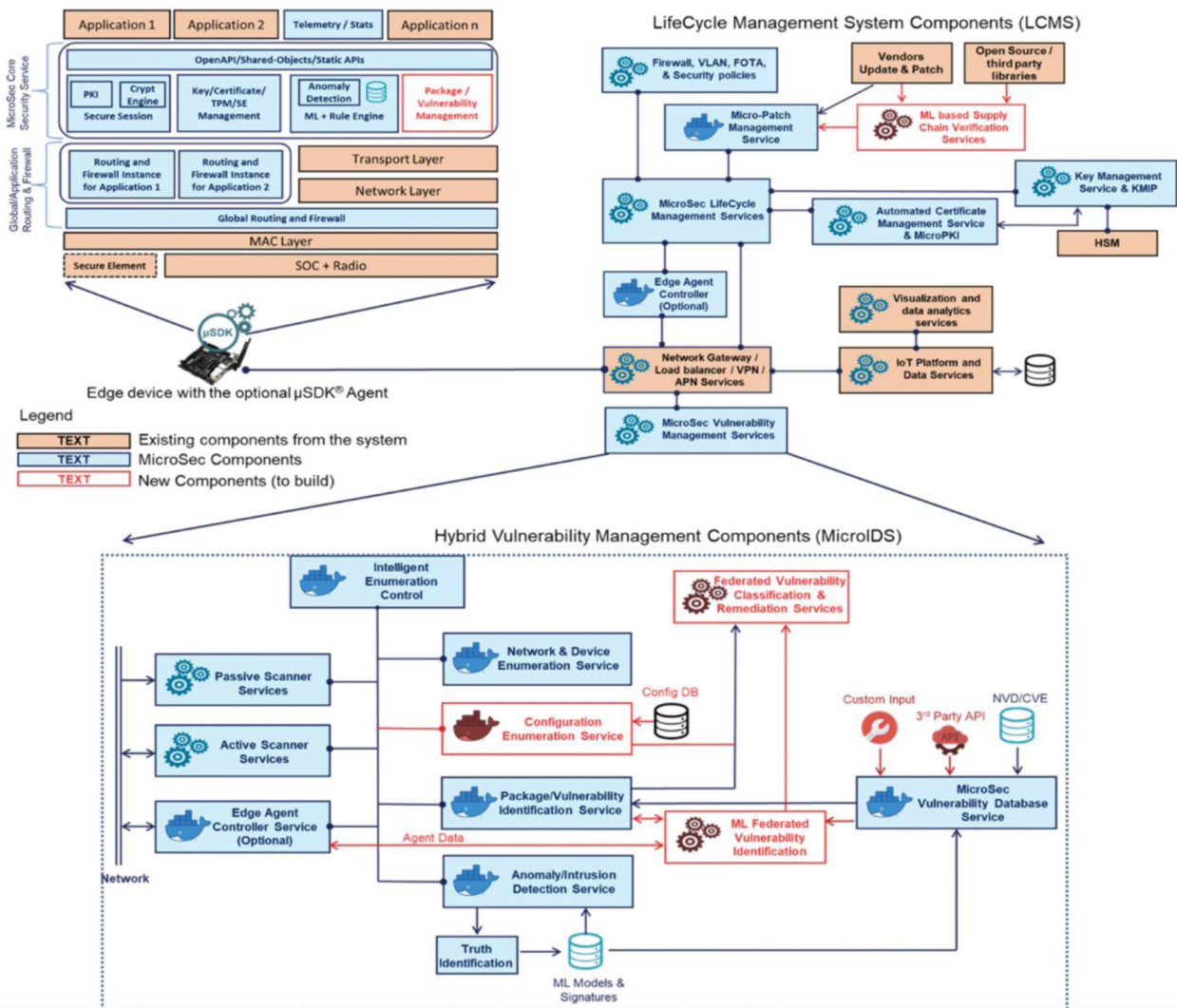


Figure 1—Conceptual architecture of the unified cybersecurity framework for Distributed Energy Systems. The framework integrates an edge agent SDK, a lifecycle management system for policy and patch management, and a hybrid vulnerability management system that uses federated learning to orchestrate threat detection across distributed energy assets [2].

Edge Security Agent. Deployed directly on DES assets- including IEDs, substation gateways, and other field controllers, the edge security agent is a lightweight software component responsible for localized data analysis and security enforcement. Its core functions are designed for high efficiency in resource-constrained environments. These functions include localized anomaly detection using machine learning, on-device vulnerability management, cryptographic key and certificate handling to establish a hardware root of trust, and local firewall rule implementation to provide an initial layer of defense against network threats [3].

Central Management and Analysis Platform. The backend platform serves as the central nervous system for the entire security framework, integrating two major service suites to deliver centralized orchestration, deep analysis, and comprehensive management for all distributed assets [3].

A. Lifecycle Management Service

This suite of services is focused on maintaining the security posture and operational integrity of all connected DES assets throughout their lifecycle. Its key components provide robust policy enforcement and asset management capabilities. The service facilitates centralized control for the remote management of firewall rules, VLAN configurations, security policies, and firmware over-the-air (FOTA) updates. This allows it to automatically update policies to isolate compromised assets or block attacks in a coordinated manner. It also includes an automated certificate and key management system, which oversees the entire lifecycle of digital certificates (e.g., X.509) via an integrated Public Key Infrastructure (PKI), ensuring that only authenticated and authorized devices can communicate. Finally, it provides services for managing software patches and verifying the integrity of third-party libraries to mitigate supply chain risks [3].

B. Hybrid Vulnerability and Anomaly Management Service

This service suite represents the core of the system's federated security intelligence, responsible for data aggregation, collaborative analysis, and threat detection across the entire network. The platform utilizes both passive scanners to monitor network traffic (e.g., Modbus, DNP3, GOOSE) and active scanners to directly query devices for deep configuration insights [3].

1. The most innovative aspect of this service is the **Federated Learning Orchestration** (Figure 2). This process facilitates collaborative machine learning without centralizing raw operational data, thereby preserving privacy and complying with data governance regulations. The orchestration follows a cyclical process.
2. The central **Federated Learning Manager** initiates the process by distributing a global machine learning model to the edge agents installed on DES assets [3].
3. Each edge agent then uses its local operational and telemetry data to train and refine its local instance of the model. This step tailors the model to the specific behavior of its host device and immediate environment [3].
4. Critically, the agents securely transmit only their updated model parameters, compact, anonymized mathematical updates, back to the central platform via a secure message broker like MQTT. The raw, sensitive operational data never leaves the device [3].
5. The Federated Learning Manager aggregates these parameters from all participating agents to create an enhanced, more intelligent global model that benefits from the collective experience of the entire network. This refined model is then redistributed to the agents for the next learning cycle [3].

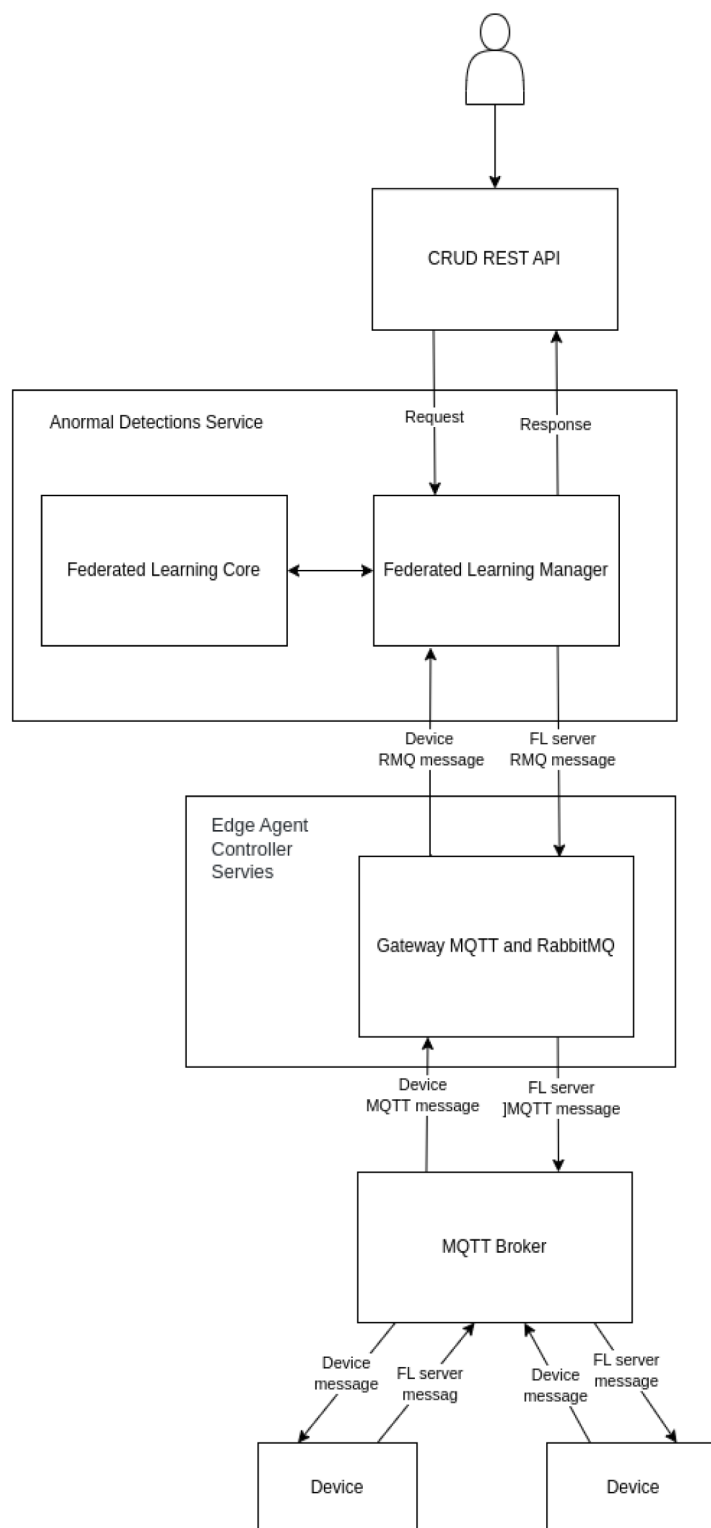
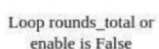


Figure 2—MicroSec Federated Learning system architecture. The architecture integrates FL Core, FL Manager (RESTful API/RMQ communication), and Edge Agent Controller (MQTT-based secure data exchange) to enable distributed model training through parameter sharing while preserving data privacy.



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single device could achieve alone, enabling a powerful and coordinated defense across the entire Distributed Energy System [3].

Experimental Validation Process

To rigorously validate the system's effectiveness against cyber threats pertinent to DES, a series of controlled experiments were conducted within a dedicated testbed environment. The validation process was engineered to assess the FL analyzer's capabilities in accurately detecting and classifying specific, simulated attack types by replicating realistic threat scenarios and monitoring for the appropriate system response [4]. These test cases focused on the full lifecycle of threat management, from initial anomaly detection and classification to final remediation, within a simulated DES network comprising multiple interconnected edge devices [4].

The experimental validation process for key cyber threats was executed as follows:

1. **Denial of Service (DoS) Attack Validation:** The primary objective was to confirm that the FL analyzer could accurately identify and classify a DoS attack. The simulation began by creating an FL analyzer on the central platform, configured to monitor a group of three edge devices representing a small-scale DES asset cluster. The system was first allowed to learn the normal operational baseline by observing standard packet rates and establishing a detection threshold. Subsequently, a DoS attack was simulated by generating and directing a significantly increased volume of packet traffic at one of the targeted devices. The validation criterion for this test was the FL analyzer's ability to detect the anomalous traffic spike, correctly classify the event as a DoS attack, and immediately trigger a corresponding alert on the system's threat dashboard [4].
2. **Jamming Attack Validation:** This test was designed to validate the system's ability to detect a jamming attack by identifying a significant and anomalous drop in the packet rate, which is indicative of intentional communication disruption. The procedure involved training the FL model on the baseline packet rate and the mean time difference between packets under normal operational conditions. The attack was then simulated by programmatically reducing or blocking legitimate packets directed to a target device, causing a distinct drop in its received packet rate. Successful validation required the system to detect this deviation from the established baseline, classify the event as a jamming attack, and generate the appropriate alert [4].
3. **Tampering Attack Validation:** This experiment was conducted to ensure the FL analyzer could detect attacks where an adversary maliciously alters network data in transit. To establish a trusted baseline, the FL model was first trained for 10 rounds on normal network behavior. A tampering attack was subsequently introduced by modifying the data within packets, such as altering the payloads or headers of communications destined for one of the edge devices. The expected outcome for successful validation was the system's ability to identify these tampered packets, score them as anomalous deviations from the learned normal behavior, and issue a classified alert [4].
4. **Replay Attack Validation:** The system's ability to thwart replay attacks was assessed by training the FL model over 10 rounds to understand the normal timing and sequencing of packet flows. Following this training, a replay attack was simulated by resending previously captured, legitimate data packets at irregular intervals to a target device. Validation hinged on the system's capacity to detect the irregular and out-of-sequence timing of these replayed packets, correctly classify the event as a replay attack, and trigger a threat alert [4].

Through this structured and methodical validation process, the system's capabilities to detect, classify, and respond to a range of critical cyber threats were empirically confirmed, demonstrating its robustness for securing distributed energy assets.

Results and Observations

Threat Detection and Model Accuracy

The effectiveness of the FL approach for threat detection was quantitatively validated through a structured, iterative training process involving multiple edge devices. The performance of the aggregated global model, which synthesizes the insights learned by individual nodes, demonstrated significant and consistent improvement across ten successive training rounds [3].

Test results reveal a clear and rapid progression in the model's capabilities. After just one round of federated training, the aggregated model achieved an accuracy of 96.80%. This performance steadily improved with each subsequent round. The True Positive Rate (TPR), which measures the model's ability to correctly identify actual threats, reached a perfect 1.000 (100%) after the very first round and maintained this ideal level throughout the remainder of the testing process. Concurrently, the False Positive Rate (FPR), a critical metric representing the rate of false alarms, exhibited a consistent decline, approaching zero by the eighth round and demonstrating the model's increasing precision [3].

Initial performance after one training round reached 96.80% accuracy, with True Positive Rate (TPR) achieving perfect 100% detection of actual threats. The False Positive Rate (FPR) consistently declined from 0.004389 to zero by the eighth round. Most significantly, the model achieved 100% accuracy by the seventh training round, maintaining perfect TPR and zero FPR for all subsequent rounds, showcasing exceptional reliability in distinguishing between benign and malicious activity.

The performance progression of the aggregated model is detailed below.

	Training Round Accuracy (%)	True Positive Rate (TPR)	False Positive Rate (FPR)
1	96.80	1.000	0.004389
2	97.05	1.000	0.004289
3	97.40	1.000	0.000410
4	98.90	1.000	0.000350
5	99.05	1.000	0.000220
6	99.20	1.000	0.000210
7	100.00	1.000	0.000000
8	100.00	1.000	0.000000
9	100.00	1.000	0.000000
10	100.00	1.000	0.000000

These quantitative results empirically confirm that the federated learning methodology not only enhances threat detection accuracy to optimal levels but also excels at minimizing false alarms. This produces a highly reliable and effective global security model suitable for deployment across diverse and critical DES assets [3].

Performance on Resource-Constrained Edge Devices

While the accuracy of the federated learning model is paramount, its practical applicability within DES is equally contingent on its operational efficiency. The energy sector's infrastructure is characterized by a vast number of geographically dispersed assets, such as IEDs, DER controllers, and substation gateways, which are often legacy systems with significant constraints on processing power, memory, and storage. The viability of any new cybersecurity solution depends on its ability to function within these hardware limitations without impeding primary operational tasks.

A critical aspect of this research, therefore, involved the rigorous assessment of the solution's performance footprint on hardware representative of these constrained environments. During functional testing, the comprehensive protection and monitoring features were deployed and run under load on a Linux (arm32) device, an architecture common in industrial hardware. The system demonstrated exceptional efficiency, requiring only **16 MB of RAM** and **25 MB of disk space** to operate [4]. Furthermore, these tests confirmed that the system performed well under high network speeds, with no negative impact on either YARA-based detection or the device's core functions [4].

This minimal resource utilization provides powerful evidence of the solution's suitability for the energy sector. It validates that an advanced, federated, and multi-layered security framework can be deployed across a wide range of existing DES assets without necessitating expensive and disruptive hardware replacement cycles. This efficiency is a critical enabler for scalable security modernization, proving that robust, next-generation threat detection can be achieved even within the operational and budgetary constraints of legacy industrial control systems.

System Capabilities Validation

Beyond individual performance metrics, the system's end-to-end operational effectiveness was confirmed through a comprehensive suite of functional tests. These tests were designed to validate the successful pass/fail outcomes for all core capabilities, from initial asset discovery to final threat remediation. The results demonstrated that every evaluated functionality met its specified passing criteria, confirming the solution's reliability and readiness for deployment in complex DES environments [2, 4].

The key functional validations are summarized as follows:

1. **Configuration Enumeration:** The system passed all tests related to the discovery and cataloging of device configurations. Active and passive scanning processes were verified to be fully operational, successfully collecting and storing critical asset data including manufacturer details, software packages, and cryptographic assets [2][4].
2. **Federated ML Threat Detection:** The federated learning analyzer proved highly effective, passing all validation tests for threat identification and classification. The system accurately detected anomalies from a range of simulated attacks pertinent to DES environments, including Denial of Service (DoS), Jamming, Tampering, and Replay attacks, and correctly classified these threats on the central dashboard [2][4].
3. **Automated Remediation:** The system's automated response capabilities were verified. Tests confirmed that remediation workflows could be successfully configured and automatically triggered in response to a classified threat, demonstrating the ability to execute actions such as device isolation or blocking without manual intervention [2][4].

Overall, the comprehensive pass ratings across all tested objectives provide a clear and positive validation of the system's end-to-end capabilities, confirming its operational effectiveness and robustness for securing critical energy infrastructure.

Novelty and Discussion

Market Differentiation and Innovation

The proposed FL framework introduces a novel and strategically significant approach to the cybersecurity of DES, differentiating itself from existing market solutions by fundamentally re-architecting where and how security intelligence is generated and applied. An analysis of the current industrial security landscape reveals that while many established platforms offer robust network monitoring and threat detection, they are predominantly built on traditional, centralized architectures. The primary innovation of this work lies in its proven ability to deploy advanced machine learning capabilities directly onto resource-constrained edge

devices and orchestrate them through a federated model, addressing critical gaps that incumbent solutions do not cover [2].

A comparative analysis against leading industrial security products underscores the solution's novelty across several key dimensions. The most significant differentiator is the system's native support for both machine learning on constrained devices, including microcontrollers, and a federated ML architecture for collaborative vulnerability detection. Leading commercial solutions from vendors such as Mocana, Tenable (Nessus), FireEye, Claroty, and Armis currently lack the capability to perform ML-driven analysis directly on such low-power edge hardware [2]. These platforms typically require operational and security data to be forwarded to a central platform or a more powerful gateway for analysis, a model that introduces inherent latency and significant data privacy concerns. By embedding intelligence at the network edge, our approach enables threat detection to occur in real-time at the source, a crucial requirement for the time-sensitive operational environment of an energy grid [2]. While traditional centralized approaches require data aggregation, federated learning enables collaborative model training without data sharing, addressing key limitations identified in recent comprehensive surveys of the field [6,9].

Furthermore, the solution provides comprehensive vulnerability management on the edge devices themselves, another capability not found in the benchmarked competitor offerings [2]. This allows for a more proactive and resilient security posture, where the state of a device can be managed locally without constant reliance on a central server. This is vital for the security of energy assets deployed in remote locations or within networks that have intermittent or low-bandwidth connectivity. The framework's integration of both active and passive scanning for a hybrid of IT and OT protocols also provides a more holistic view than many specialized solutions [2].

In summary, while existing tools continue to refine centralized data analysis, this research pioneers a decentralized, edge-native intelligence model. The ability to execute ML models on constrained IEDs and then leverage Federated Learning to build collective, fleet-wide intelligence without centralizing raw operational data represents a paradigm shift in industrial cybersecurity. This approach is uniquely suited to the evolving technical and regulatory landscape of modern energy systems, which are increasingly distributed, dependent on legacy hardware, and subject to stringent data privacy and operational security requirements.

Practical Challenges and Lessons Learned

The transition from a theoretical framework to a practical, scalable cybersecurity solution for DES revealed several implementation challenges. Overcoming these obstacles provided critical insights into deploying FL effectively in complex, real-world operational environments. The primary challenges can be categorized into three key areas: managing the inherent diversity of device data, ensuring scalability within strict hardware resource constraints, and balancing real-time threat detection with the operational need to reduce excessive alert volumes [2].

Managing Data Heterogeneity and FL Optimization. A significant challenge in the project was ensuring high model accuracy in the face of diverse data originating from a wide array of IoT and IIoT devices across the energy grid. Federated learning models depend on data from each device, but the data varied significantly in volume, structure, and quality. This heterogeneity complicated the process of centralized aggregation and negatively impacted the overall model's effectiveness, as a single global model struggled to perform optimally across all device types [2].

Data heterogeneity is a well-documented challenge in federated learning environments [6]. The clustering approach implemented addresses the non-IID (independent and identically distributed) data problem commonly encountered in real-world FL deployments [7]. The implemented solution was to move beyond a one-size-fits-all approach. Devices were strategically grouped into **homogeneous clusters** based on their data characteristics. Each of these clusters was then assigned a dedicated FL analyzer. This approach enabled

tailored model training that was specifically optimized for the data patterns of that group, significantly enhancing the anomaly detection capabilities for each device type and, in turn, the accuracy of the aggregated global models [2].

Scalability and Resource Constraints. Supporting a large and expanding network of energy assets, many of which possess limited processing power and memory, demanded careful architectural design and model optimization. The solution had to be both scalable to thousands of nodes and efficient enough to operate on constrained hardware without impeding primary operational functions [2].

A two-pronged strategy was deployed to address this challenge:

1. **Scalable Architecture:** The system was engineered with a **modular architecture**, allowing for the independent scaling of individual components. Each edge device operated within its own self-contained module, a design that prevented performance bottlenecks at the system level and enabled a smoother scaling process across the network [2].
2. **Optimized Models:** A tiered approach to model deployment was adopted. **Lightweight versions** of the FL and anomaly detection models were specifically developed and deployed for the most resource-constrained devices. More complex and computationally intensive models were reserved for higher-capacity devices. This tailored approach ensured detection effectiveness was maintained across all device types without degrading performance [2].

Federated Learning Limitations and Security Considerations. Despite demonstrated effectiveness, several inherent limitations must be acknowledged for future deployment considerations. Model poisoning attacks represent a significant concern in FL environments, where malicious participants can deliberately introduce corrupted data or adversarial updates to degrade the global model's performance [9]. In energy systems, a compromised device could potentially inject malicious parameters that affect the entire network's threat detection capabilities. Mitigation strategies include implementing robust participant validation, anomaly detection for model updates, and byzantine fault tolerance mechanisms.

Latency trade-offs present another operational consideration. While edge processing reduces data transmission latency, the iterative nature of federated learning introduces model synchronization delays. In ultra-time-sensitive energy grid operations where millisecond responses are critical, this trade-off between collaborative intelligence and immediate local response must be carefully balanced through hybrid approaches that maintain local decision-making capabilities while benefiting from global learning.

Scalability challenges in ultra-large networks become pronounced as participating devices grow beyond thousands to tens of thousands of nodes. The current architecture demonstrated effectiveness across 20+ nodes, but scaling to utility-grade deployments with 100,000+ devices introduces computational and communication bottlenecks at the central aggregation point. Solutions include hierarchical federated learning architectures, edge clustering with regional aggregators, and adaptive communication protocols that reduce synchronization frequency for stable models while maintaining rapid updates for emerging threats.

Conclusion

This paper has introduced a novel cybersecurity framework that successfully leverages Federated Learning (FL) to address the complex security, privacy, and operational challenges inherent in modern DES. The research demonstrated a practical and effective method for deploying advanced threat detection capabilities directly onto resource-constrained edge devices, such as IEDs and substation gateways, without compromising data privacy or device performance [3].

The key achievements of this work are empirically validated and represent a significant advancement over existing commercial solutions. The federated learning model demonstrated exceptional threat detection capabilities, achieving **100% accuracy** with a false positive rate of zero after iterative training rounds,

proving its ability to reliably identify threats within DES environments [3]. Crucially, this high level of security was achieved with remarkable efficiency. Performance testing confirmed that the edge agent operates with a minimal resource footprint, utilizing just **16 MB of RAM and 25 MB of disk space** on a representative Linux-based edge device [4]. This confirms the solution's suitability for deployment across the vast number of legacy and new devices in the energy sector that have limited computational resources.

By combining on-device machine learning with a federated architecture, the solution provides a scalable and resilient framework that protects sensitive operational data by keeping it at the edge, a critical requirement for regulatory compliance. The system's effectiveness in configuration management, threat classification, and automated remediation was successfully verified through rigorous functional testing [4][2]. Ultimately, this project has produced a robust, platform-independent cybersecurity solution that is validated and ready for deployment, offering a new blueprint for securing the next generation of distributed and interconnected energy networks [3].

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